



VIRUSES

They're out to get you!

Just like their biological counterparts, computer viruses are malicious, destructive and unwelcome. Anything from that innocuous little file, to the floppy that your best friend lent you could carry one of these miscreants. They infect and destroy everything including the boot sector of your system, your documents, your precious e-mails and operating system essentials. Like their biological cousins, they mutate and propagate, making them difficult to track and kill. And just as thousands of years of progress hasn't rid the world of the common cold virus, computer viruses are also here to stay and will remain a rather large and irritating thorn in our sides. Moreover, as the sands of progress seep into every nook and cranny of our lives, the havoc wreaked by viruses will only increase manifold. A virus is indiscriminating by nature—your cell-phone or the PDA are equally susceptible to it. The omnipresence of computer viruses has made anti-virus solutions an integral part of every computer user's life. Such software is largely preventive in nature, snipping a virus in the bud and monitoring your system for

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According to the research company Computer Economics, the Code Red virus caused damages worth about \$2.6 billion in the year 2001. The same research group estimated the Love Bug to have caused damages worth a colossal \$10 billion worldwide

possible attacks. So, even though the software takes up precious system resources, ensure that it is always running on your computer and is monitoring it. Anti-virus software track down malevolent viruses using a database that lists all identified viruses and the means to remove them. This list is frequently updated and in order to ensure maximum protection, it is vital that you update the software at least once every month.

And beware of floppies! They are infamous for spreading viruses and their ilk. Before using a floppy, ensure that you have scanned its contents—more so, if you plan to boot from it. Extend the same preventive measure to e-mail attachments and to unknown macros. Whenever you doubt the nature of a file, or your system seems to act unnaturally, run a virus scan.



POPUP ADS

In your face and painful

Ever since the Internet caught the media's attention, the fact that it reaches a large and varied segment of people caught every marketing department's eye and banner ads were born. The logic was simple—if they put ads on a Web page, surely the people would be interested and click on them. This led to bigger and more eye-catching ads and soon there were animated ads that played sound effects and music. This is where things began to go woefully wrong and increasingly irritating. What followed was the popup ad: a devious ploy to get the attention of users who were obviously giving no love to the ad makers. These nasties pop up and out of a Web site, and the ads themselves run the gamut of stupidity.

Two worthy competitors to Microsoft's Internet Explorer (IE) browser have elegant solutions that help put these ads where the sun don't shine. The latest version of both Opera and Mozilla feature ways to prevent ads, but if you prefer to stick with IE and not jump browsers, then Pop-Up Stopper (www.panicware.com) will take care of just such a need.



SPAM

You've got spam!

It is a beautiful morning, one of those days when you feel that you can conquer the world. You take care of your chores, open your mailbox and out flood messages that promise a free trip to Hawaii, a better love-life and other such mails that overwhelm both your senses and your computer system. You have been spammed. What are you going to do about it?

There are certain practices that help reduce the amount of spam you receive—they vary in effectiveness and ease of use. The first thing to do is to create two e-mail IDs: a personal one for friends, family and colleagues, and a second public ID for the rest of the online world. Services that require your e-mail address, such as newsletters or messageboards, should be given the public mail ID.

A second option is the filter offered by most e-mail clients and services. These let you sort your inbound mail according to the address of the mail sender, directing the mail sent by someone on your address book into a separate folder, while another folder holds the mail that has originated from an unknown source.

Finally, there are software solu-

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According to analyst Jupiter Media Metrix, each e-mail user in the US received an estimated 595 spam e-mails in 2001. The number is expected to rise to 1,671 by the year 2006

tions such as SpamNet (www.cloudmark.com) that protect you against 80 per cent of spam. These work on the strength of blacklists: databases that contain addresses that are known to generate spam mail. These services are largely effective but have been known to slip-up occasionally and block a valid e-mail.

Nevertheless, a combination of all three solutions can be formidable, reducing spam to a number close to, if not quite zero.